We all have moments when we wonder who we are, and where we are going. The privilege of recognition, in all its forms, gives you the gift of reflection. A series of questions began to take shape: What were the fundamental lessons I had learned along the way? How would I use them? Would I be capable of living my life at a different pace?

One of my earliest lessons in cricket was also one of the most important: you can't do things on your own, but ultimately you will be defined as an individual, despite it being a team sport. I owe an enormous debt of gratitude to Graham Gooch, a constant presence for most of my career, but had to do things my way. I was the one who walked out there to bat. There was no one holding my hand when I did so.

I accept I was entrenched in my ideas. I am notoriously stubborn. Logically, if that approach had worked for me as a player, why would it not work for me as a captain? Going back to that conversation with Andy Flower, I knew I didn't know everything, but was so scared of wandering off, listening to too many people and becoming a victim of muddied thinking that I was too reserved.

It was only as I became more comfortable in my skin as a captain that I realized I had to be more collaborative. Talking to people who see things from a different angle is rejuvenating. It gives you additional ideas, shares and lessens the burden. Self-imposed pressure eases, because you are not preoccupied with keeping things close to your chest.

I wish I had done so earlier, but how would I have known, straight away, that was the right thing to do? We are who we are. Given the multifaceted nature of the job of England captain, there has to be an element of trial and error. It is a very different challenge, even if your leadership style is seasoned in county cricket.

It's a dissimilar situation, a different job but an amazing job. There's no doubt it brought out my natural resilience. Living through the KP affair proved to me that if I have something in which I believe I will keep ploughing on. I've always been fascinated by the psychology of personal achievement, especially when there is a physical element to the challenge.

I've read a lot about the SAS, and the quiet fortitude of their guys. They don't show out. They never strut around. They step back, analyse and act. I would love to spend time with them, to discover the true meaning of mental strength. Everyone says I have it, but it is also my comfort blanket. Do I take it for granted, or can I develop it into other areas?